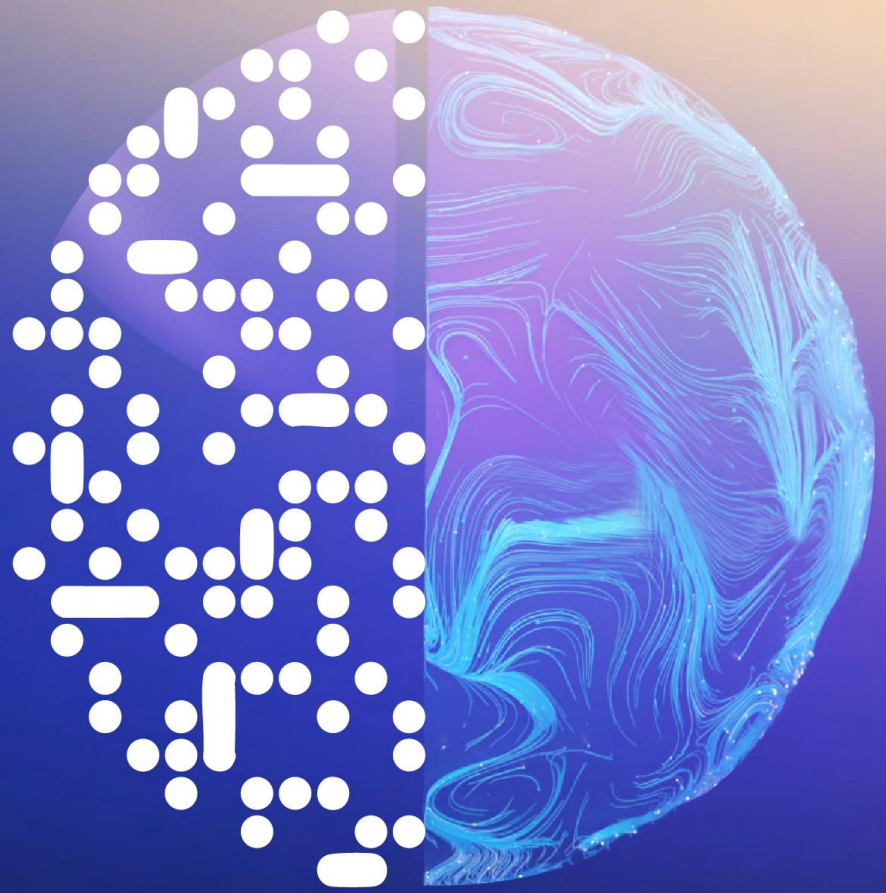
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THREE-DAY INNOVATION Journey

From Challenge to Impact

Three days. One challenge. A solution worth developing.

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"IF YOU HAVE A POSITIVE OUTLOOK, YOU WILL SEE OPPORTUNITIES IN CHALLENGES, SUCCESS IN THE FUTURE, & IN PEOPLE ENERGIES & TALENTS”

His Highness, Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum



Your Innovation Journey

From Challenge to Impact

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FROM CHALLENGE TO IMPACT

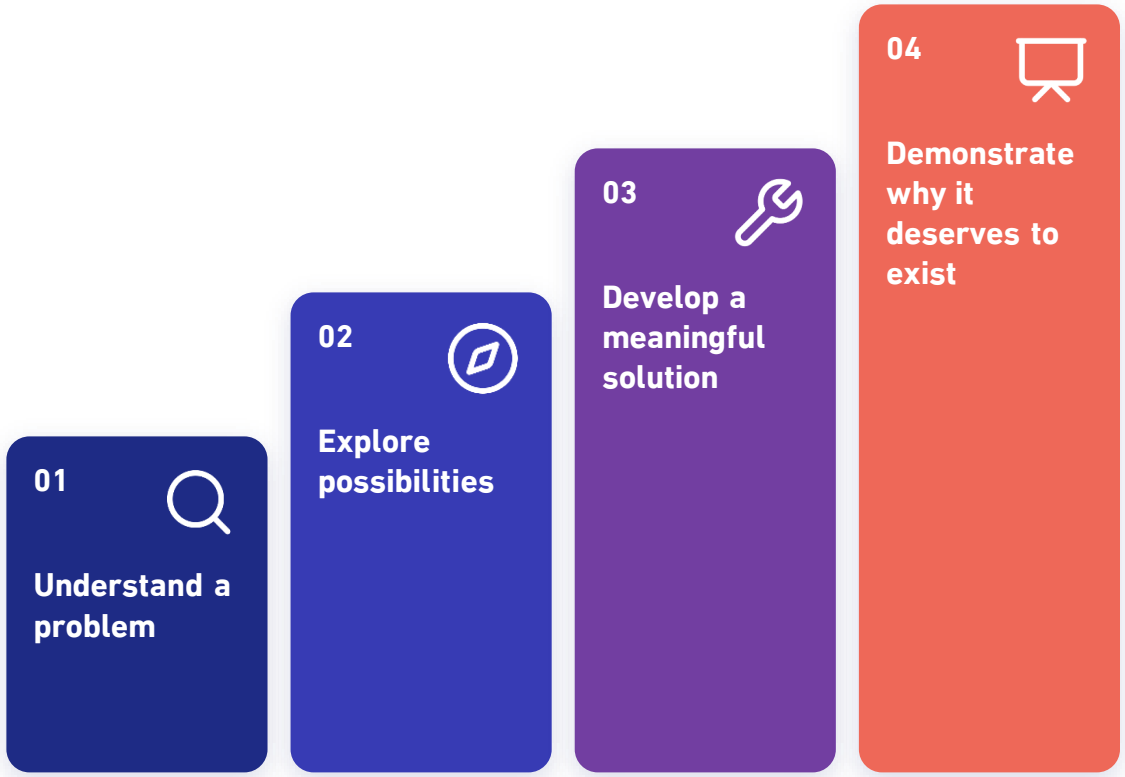
Innovation is not about having the most ideas.

It is about understanding a problem, exploring possibilities, developing a meaningful solution, and demonstrating why it deserves to exist.

YOUR MISSION

Move beyond the idea.
Build the case for your solution.

WHAT INNOVATION REALLY TAKES



LET'S DISCUSS

“Imagine you have an idea that could solve a real problem.

What would you need to prove before someone would invest in it, adopt it, or use it?”

WHAT YOU MIGHT HEAR

- **People actually need it**
- **It works**
- **It is affordable**
- **It is different from existing solutions**
- **People would use it**

Innovation requires more than creativity: a genuine need, real value, feasibility and a convincing case.

The Three-Day Journey

From problem to pitch: one connected journey

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DAY 1
UNDERSTAND & EXPLORE

FOCUS

Understand the challenge and discover opportunities.

KEY ACTIVITIES

Analyze the problem, identify affected users, define needs, generate ideas, and select a promising direction.

EXPECTED OUTPUTS

A clearly defined problem, a target user, and a selected solution concept.

DAY 2
DEVELOP & VALIDATE

FOCUS

Strengthen the solution and its value proposition.

KEY ACTIVITIES

Receive mentorship, refine the concept, explore feasibility, develop and test a prototype or representation, and begin structuring the business model.

EXPECTED OUTPUTS

A refined solution concept, feedback or validation insights, and a developed Business Model Canvas.

DAY 3
REFINE & PITCH

FOCUS

Build a convincing case for the solution.

KEY ACTIVITIES

Finalize the business model, strengthen the value proposition, prepare the presentation, and pitch to the judging panel.

EXPECTED OUTPUTS

A completed Business Model Canvas, a final pitch, and a clear explanation of the solution's potential impact.

UNDERSTAND → DEFINE → IDEATE → DEVELOP → TEST → MODEL → PITCH

↺ *This sequence is the overall journey. Teams may revisit earlier stages when feedback reveals that an assumption needs to be reconsidered.*

QUICK POLL

"Which do you think is riskier?"



OPTION A

Developing a solution before understanding the problem

VS



OPTION B

Pitching a solution before understanding how it creates value



Both are risky. Each stage builds on the evidence, decisions and outputs of the previous one. The objective is not a fully functioning product, but a promising solution concept you can substantiate.

The Innovation Pathway

One methodology, seven connected stages

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01 UNDERSTAND	02 DEFINE	03 IDEATE	04 DEVELOP	05 TEST	06 MODEL	07 PITCH
GUIDING QUESTION	GUIDING QUESTION	GUIDING QUESTION	GUIDING QUESTION	GUIDING QUESTION	GUIDING QUESTION	GUIDING QUESTION
Who experiences the challenge, and what do we know about it?	What specific problem are we trying to solve?	What different approaches could address the problem?	How can we make the concept tangible?	What do we need to learn or validate?	How will the solution create, deliver, and sustain value?	Why should someone support or adopt this solution?
OUTPUT **Challenge analysis and user insights**	OUTPUT **Focused problem statement**	OUTPUT **Alternative ideas and selected concept**	OUTPUT **Refined solution and prototype or representation**	OUTPUT **Feedback, insights, and improved assumptions**	OUTPUT **Advanced Business Model Canvas**	OUTPUT **Final pitch and supporting evidence**

Testing and feedback may lead teams to revisit earlier stages

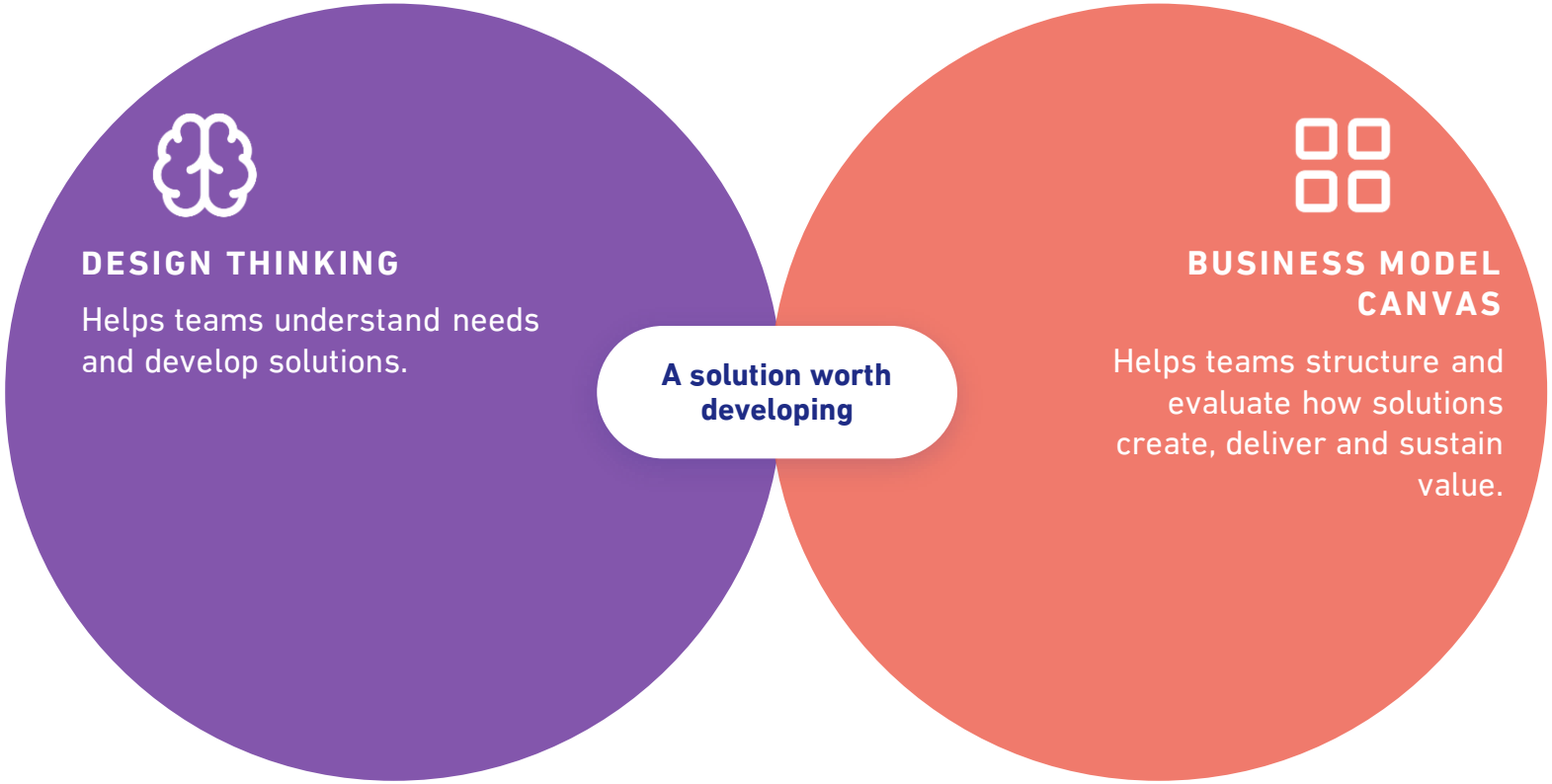
Exact activities and deliverables align with the official Hackathon schedule and judging framework.

Two Complementary Lenses

Design Thinking and Business Model Canvas

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Design Thinking and the Business Model Canvas serve complementary purposes.



Understand · Define · Ideate · Develop · Test

↺ *Testing and feedback may lead teams to revisit earlier stages*

Model · Pitch

01 UNDERSTAND | 02 DEFINE | 03 IDEATE | 04 DEVELOP | 05 TEST | 06 MODEL | 07 PITCH

Start with the Problem. Not the Idea

Design Thinking: understand before you solve

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Design Thinking is a human-centered approach to innovation. It helps teams understand people's needs, challenge assumptions, explore possibilities, and develop solutions that create value.

STEP 1 · UNDERSTAND

Investigate the challenge before proposing solutions.

- **Who experiences this problem?**
- **What makes it difficult or important?**
- **What do we know, and what are we assuming?**
- **What evidence would help us understand it better?**

STEP 2 · DEFINE

Turn your findings into a clear problem statement.

THE USER
Who experiences the problem?

+

THE NEED
What do they need to achieve?

+

THE INSIGHT
Why is the problem worth solving?

= A FOCUSED PROBLEM STATEMENT

From Broad Challenge to Focused Problem

Example

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BROAD CHALLENGE



Improving Student Access to educational opportunities in the UAE

Focus it

FOCUSED PROBLEM STATEMENT

"University students need a simpler way to discover and access educational opportunities because they may not know which services are available or how to navigate the application process".

USER NEED INSIGHT

This statement identifies a potential user group, a need, and a reason to investigate the problem. It does not assume that a particular solution is necessarily the answer.

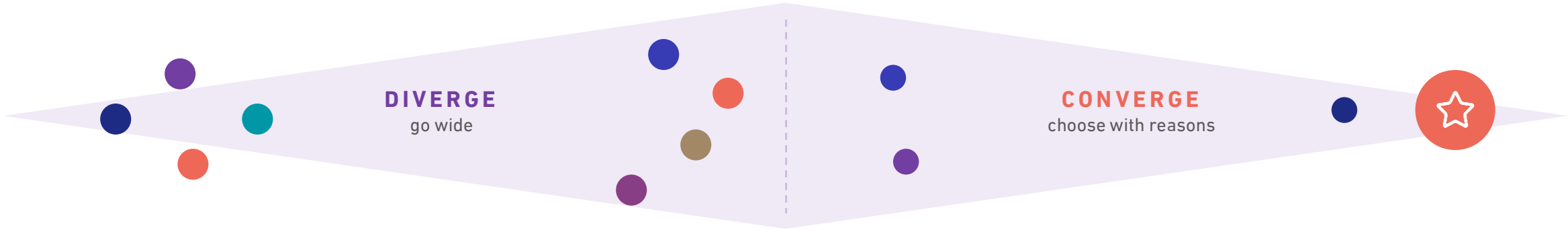
Ideation: Explore before You Select

Diverge first, then converge

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Ideation is about exploring possibilities, not settling for the first idea.

Once the problem is clearly defined, your team moves from understanding the challenge to exploring different ways to address it.



1 Generate

Produce multiple possible solutions before judging them.

2 Expand

Explore different approaches and challenge initial assumptions.

3 Compare

Consider user value, feasibility, originality, and potential impact.

4 Select

Choose the concept your team can best develop and justify.

Mentorship: Turn Feedback into Progress

Make every mentoring interaction count

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Mentors help you think better. They do not do the thinking for you.

Throughout the hackathon, mentorship is an opportunity to challenge assumptions, identify weaknesses, and strengthen your solution.

BEFORE THE SESSION

- Know what your team is trying to achieve.
- Identify your biggest uncertainty.
- Prepare specific questions.

DURING THE SESSION

- Explain your reasoning.
- Listen to constructive criticism.
- Ask for clarification when needed.
- Record recommendations and insights.

AFTER THE SESSION

- Discuss the feedback as a team.
- Decide what to adopt, adapt, or investigate further.
- Translate useful feedback into concrete next steps.

YOUR CALL

"If a mentor tells you that your idea may not work, what should you do?"

A

Defend your idea immediately.

B

Abandon it without discussion.

★ Best answer

C

Understand the concern, examine the evidence, and decide how to respond.

Disagreement with a mentor is not necessarily a problem. What matters is whether your team can justify its decisions with evidence and sound reasoning. Mentors are resources, not substitutes for team ownership.

Develop, Prototype, and Test

Make the core idea tangible

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A promising idea is a hypothesis. Test it before you assume it will work.

At this stage, teams move from describing a solution to making its core idea more tangible and examining whether its assumptions hold up.

What does prototyping mean? A simple representation of your solution that helps people understand it and allows your team to examine important assumptions.

- **Hand-drawn design or storyboard**
- **Mock-up of an application**
- **Demonstration of how a service would operate**
- **Process map of how a system would work**
- **Sample product or basic proof of concept**



Keep it simple and purposeful: focus on a prototype or representation and meaningful validation, not a complete product.

What Should You Test?

Assumptions that can make or break your solution

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	ASSUMPTION	WHAT YOU COULD TEST
DESIRABILITY	**Students would use a campus food-sharing service.**	Ask potential users about their current behavior and willingness to participate.
FEASIBILITY	**Cafeterias would share surplus food.**	Explore operational constraints and discuss the idea with relevant stakeholders.
VIABILITY	**The service would be affordable to operate.**	Estimate costs and examine possible operating models.

Testing can involve...

- Feedback from potential users
- Mentor input
- Stakeholder insights
- A simple demonstration

YOUR CALL

"You have one hour to improve your solution. Which is more useful?"



Adding five new features

+1 +1 +1 +1 +1

VS

★ Start here



Discovering whether your target users actually need your core feature

Validate the core need



Investigate the core need first. Testing is not about proving your idea right. It is about learning what needs to change.

From Solution to Business Model

The Business Model Canvas: nine building blocks

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A solution creates value. A business model explains how that value can be delivered and sustained.

1 Key Partnerships

Who could help you implement or scale it?

2 Key Activities

What must you do to deliver the solution?

3 Key Resources

What people, technology, assets, or capabilities will you need?

4 Value Propositions

What problem do you solve, and why does your solution matter?

5 Customer Relationships

How will you attract, support, and retain them?

6 Channels

How will you reach your target users or customers?

7 Customer Segments

Who are you creating value for?

8 Cost Structure

What are the main costs involved?

9 Revenue Streams

Where will the money or financial support come from?

What Makes Your BMC Advanced?

Build a connected and defensible model

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Do not simply fill in nine boxes. Build a connected and defensible model.

- Align the value proposition with a clearly defined user or customer.
- Explain how the solution will reach its intended audience.
- Identify the resources, activities, and partnerships required.

Advanced BMC

- Estimate the main costs and identify credible funding or revenue mechanisms.
- Examine the assumptions, risks, and dependencies that could affect implementation.
- Explain how the solution could scale and create measurable impact.

The Final Pitch: Make Your Case

Six questions every compelling pitch answers

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Your pitch is not just a presentation. It is an argument for your solution.

By Day 3, your team must be able to explain what you are solving, why your approach matters, and how the solution could be implemented.

1 THE PROBLEM

What challenge are you addressing, and who experiences it?

2 THE SOLUTION

What are you proposing, and how does it work?

3 THE VALUE

Why is your solution relevant, distinctive, and worth adopting?

4 THE VALIDATION

What have you learned, tested, or established about your assumptions?

5 THE BUSINESS MODEL

Who are your users and customers? What resources, partnerships, and funding or revenue mechanisms would support the solution?

6 THE IMPACT

What would success look like, and how could you measure it?

AI as Your Co-Creator

Built into every phase of the methodology

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Expect to use AI heavily, in every phase. It works alongside your team; it does not replace your thinking.

UNDERSTAND	DEFINE	IDEATE	DEVELOP	TEST	MODEL	PITCH
AI HELPS	AI HELPS	AI HELPS	AI HELPS	AI HELPS	AI HELPS	AI HELPS
Research the challenge, summarize sources, and map who is affected.	Draft and sharpen problem statements; check they don't assume a solution.	Generate many ideas fast and push for unexpected angles.	Create mock-ups, storyboards, and process maps in minutes.	Draft interview questions and find patterns in feedback.	Stress-test the BMC: estimate costs, spot risks and gaps.	Structure the story, polish visuals, and rehearse judges' Q&A.

AI CO-CREATOR ACROSS EVERY PHASE

TEMPLATES PROVIDED FOR EACH PHASE

- Challenge analysis
- Problem statement
- Idea selection
- Prototype brief
- Test plan
- Business Model Canvas
- Pitch deck

AI accelerates. Your team decides.

- Verify facts and sources
- Apply your own judgment
- Be transparent about AI use

What Is Expected of You?

Your team's progress depends on how you participate

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Attendance and commitment

Attend the required Hackathon activities and technical sessions, follow the announced schedule, and meet deadlines.

Teamwork

Share responsibilities, listen to different perspectives, communicate respectfully, and contribute to collective decisions.

Active engagement

Participate in discussions, complete the assigned activities, ask questions, and contribute to problem-solving.

Technical learning

Use the learning resources available through TDRA Academy to strengthen your understanding of relevant concepts and tools.

Mentorship

Arrive prepared, seek constructive feedback, and apply relevant insights to improve your solution.

Ownership

Take responsibility for your team's decisions and outputs rather than waiting for others to do the work.

Pitch preparation

Develop your presentation progressively, keep your business model consistent with your solution, and ensure every team member understands the final proposal.

Don't wait for Day 3.

Your pitch should evolve as your understanding of the challenge and your solution develops.

01 UNDERSTAND | 02 DEFINE | 03 IDEATE | 04 DEVELOP | 05 TEST | 06 MODEL | 07 PITCH

Your Innovation Challenge Starts Now

Before you start, remember

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THINK LIKE
AN INNOVATOR

WORK LIKE
A TEAM

BUILD WITH
PURPOSE

BEFORE YOU START, REMEMBER

- ✓ **Understand** before you solve.
- ✓ **Explore** before you select.
- ✓ **Test** before you assume.
- ✓ **Build a model** before you pitch.
- ✓ **Use feedback** to improve.
- ✓ **Explain** the value and impact of your solution.

01 UNDERSTAND | 02 DEFINE | 03 IDEATE | 04 DEVELOP | 05 TEST | 06 MODEL | 07 PITCH

"At the end of these three days, what will make you proud of your team's work?"

Your goal is not simply to leave with an idea. **It is to leave with...**

A solution
you can explain

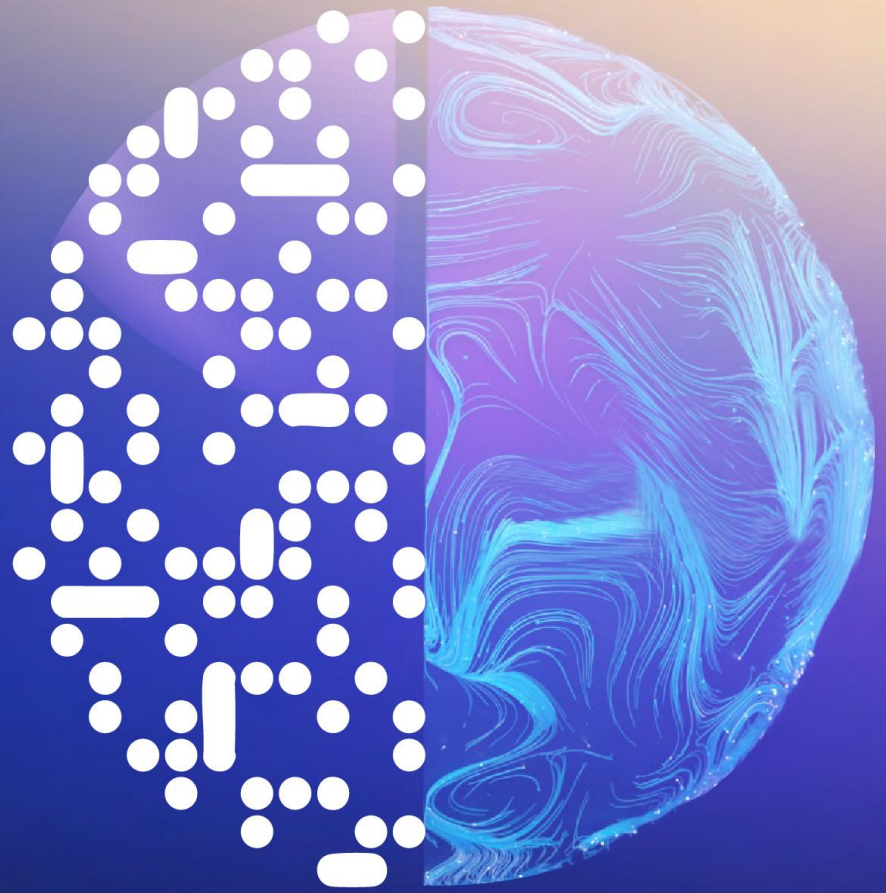
A model
you can defend

A clear understanding
of what it would take to turn that solution into impact

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